COMPOSITION OF THE COUNCIL OF MINISTERS

The council of ministers consists of three categories of ministers, namely, cabinet ministers, ministers of state, and deputy ministers. The difference between them lies in their respective ranks, emoluments, and political importance. At the top of all these ministers stands the Prime Minister—the supreme governing authority of the country.

At times, the council of ministers may also include a deputy prime minister. The deputy prime ministers are appointed mostly for political reasons.

The cabinet ministers head the important ministries of the Central government like home, defence, finance, external affairs and so forth. They are members of the cabinet, attend its meetings and play an important role in deciding policies. Thus, their responsibilities extend over the entire gamut of Central government.

The ministers of state can either be given independent charge of ministries/departments or can be attached to cabinet ministers. In case of attachment, they may either be given the charge of departments of the ministries headed by the cabinet ministers or allotted specific items of work related to the ministries headed by cabinet ministers. In both the cases, they work under the supervision and guidance as well as under the overall charge and responsibility of the cabinet ministers. In case of independent charge, they perform the same functions and exercise the same powers in relation to their ministries/departments as cabinet ministers do. However, they are not members of the cabinet and do not attend the cabinet meetings unless specially invited when something related to their ministries/departments are considered by the cabinet.

Table 21.1 Distinction Between Council of Ministers and Cabinet

Council of ministers	Cabinet
1. It is a wider body.	1. It is a smaller body.
2. It includes all the three categories of ministers, that is, cabinet ministers, ministers of state, and deputy ministers.	2. It includes the cabinet ministers only. Thus, it is a part of the council of ministers.
3. It does not meet, as a body, to transact government business. It has no collective functions.	3. It meets, as a body, frequently and usually once in a week to deliberate and take decisions regarding the transaction of government business. Thus, it has collective functions.
4. It is vested with all powers but in theory.	4. It exercises, in practice, the powers of the council of ministers and thus, acts for the latter.